

The outdoor swimming pool at the Waghoba Eco Lodge offers scenic views

weekend, a luxury wilderness resort set in the heart of the buffer zone of Tadoba Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra's Chandrapur district.

Our safari had begun at the crack of dawn. After an hour of searching, we had our first real lead—a clear, four-toed tiger pugmark, an unmistakable lazy-gait swipe at the heel, lightly embedded in the damp clay, left behind by one of the 100-odd tigers that call Tadoba their home.

I feel a sighting may be close but recall what my cab driver Jabir said on the two-hour trip from Nagpur airport to the lodge the night before: "I've encountered tigers—some crossing the road we're on right now. Running into one is really a matter of fate," he quipped. Having never seen a tiger in the wild, I had high hopes on this trip. Surely, I was in the right place for it.

The newest offering by Pugdundee Safaris, Waghoba Eco Lodge is a down-to-earth, sustainability-conscious property located at a half-hour distance from the Khutawunda and Moharli gates leading into Tadoba's core wilderness. Surrounded by open spaces and jungle-encrusted hillocks, the 12-acre property sits nestled amidst wildflowers, native grasses and trees in an unmanicured sprawl, perfectly in tune with the rustic landscape.

This seamlessness is hardly by accident—great care was taken in its three-year construction to ensure its presence impacts the area as little as possible. Mughdha Deshpande, another naturalist there, cites some examples: "Sun-baked adobe bricks made from local soil and stone ensure that degradation does not introduce non-native materials into the land. Overlapping burnt-clay cylinders forming the guna vault ceilings in every room helps reduce air-conditioning needs." The land itself, once barren and overgrazed, is being revived. "Only vegetation that thrives here naturally are planted," says Mughdha. From composting to rainwater harvesting, Waghoba employs a variety of eco-friendly ways to sustain its needs. "We even have our own plant-based sewage treatment plant that feeds clean water into a bird hide—a small waterbody where many small animals come for a sip," she adds.

Larger fauna—sambar and spotted deer, gaur, wild boars, nilgai, wild dogs, sloth bears, tigers and leopards—limit their ambit to the thicker cover of the forest, though herbivores often venture into crop fields at night. We encounter most of these as our jeep winds through teak, jamun, flame of the forest and ghost trees as kingfishers, egrets and hornbills flit through the air. Along the banks of Lake Tadoba, a pair of Nilgai fawns chase each other while the adults stop for a drink. They don't seem to notice the large marsh crocodile only a few feet away, imperceptible but for the trained eyes of my guides. Perhaps we've been just as oblivious to a nearby tiger, camouflaged amidst the tall, winter-yellowed fronds and bamboo groves.

As we head back from the safari, the forest, as if sensing my disappointment, seems to offer some rare run-ins as recompense: a massive Sambar buck preening at a watering hole, a four-horned antelope (chausingha)—an exceedingly shy and skittish ungulate—with her days-old infant.